

MCP vs API

Admins ask which one to use and usually get a vague answer. Here's a straight one, with the scenarios to back it up.

01 · THE DIFFERENCE

Same capabilities, built for different users

API

BUILT FOR CODE

A developer writes code that calls one exact endpoint, with exact parameters, in an exact format. It does the same thing every time.

```
GET /accounts/{id}/activity
?since=2026-09-01&type=meeting
```

MCP

BUILT FOR AI

The AI sees which tools are available, picks the one that fits the question, and fills in the details from what the person asked.

"Who have we met with at **Halden Freight** this month?"

EXAMPLES ARE ILLUSTRATIVE, NOT REAL BACKSTORY ENDPOINTS

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

API You fill out the form yourself, every field, every time.

MCP You say what you need. Someone who knows the forms picks the right one and fills it in.

NOT EITHER/OR

MCP doesn't replace the API. It can sit on top of an existing API and give AI a standard way to use it.

Person → Claude → MCP → API → Backstory data

02 · WHICH ONE?

Ask who's on the other end, and whether the question changes

Use MCP when

- A person is in the loop
- The question changes each time
- The answer needs judgment, not a fixed format

Use the API when

- The same job runs on a schedule
- The output has to be exact, every time
- The result feeds another system

The gray zone

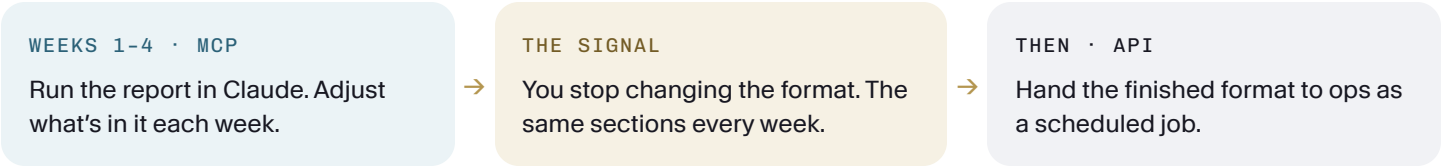
Recurring reports a person still reviews. Start with MCP. Move to the API once the format stops changing.

RULE OF THUMB If a person is asking, use MCP. *If a system is asking, use the API.*

Eight common jobs, *sorted*

THE JOB	USE	WHY
A rep preps for tomorrow’s call with Halden Freight	MCP	A person asks, and the follow-ups depend on the answer
A manager digs into why a commit deal slipped	MCP	Every question leads somewhere new
A VP researches win patterns for the QBR	MCP	Open-ended, and the story takes judgment
Nightly sync of activity data into the data warehouse	API	Runs on a schedule and feeds another system
Writing engagement scores to CRM fields	API	Exact values, same format, no one reviewing
A Slack alert when a commit deal loses exec contact	API	Triggered by a rule, not a question
Board metrics that must match finance exactly	API	Precision beats flexibility
Weekly pipeline risk summary a leader reviews before sending	MCP → API	Gray zone: shape it in MCP, then automate it

WORKING THE GRAY ZONE



WHY THIS MATTERS FOR GTM

AI stops being another tab. *It becomes the layer across the stack.*

GTM stacks keep splitting: CRM, sales intelligence, email, content, enrichment, analytics. MCP gives AI one standard way into each of them, so it can understand how your system fits together and act across it, not just draft messages. The chat window starts to work like the operating system for your GTM motion.

WORTH KNOWING

Access works differently. MCP uses each person’s own Backstory permissions. API integrations are usually set up and scoped by an admin. Confirm with your Backstory team how API access works for your workspace.